

venturing into the woods, where they encounter new surroundings, allowing their brains to unwind from the constant focus on training in the arena," says Agarwalla.

Horse like Ronaldo

A horse's need to take a break depends on multiple factors — when they last competed, what they are peaking towards and, more so, the age of the horse. "Sir Caramello is physically very strong but at the same time he is 17 years old, which is fairly old for a horse. I'm not going to stretch my luck with him," says Agarwalla.

Agarwalla compares him to any other high performance athlete who is at the end of their career. "If I had to compare Sir Caramello to anyone, it would be Cristiano Ronaldo. Both are approaching the end of their careers. But at the same time both are really experienced and motivated to give their best. Ronaldo is still among the best in his league and scoring goals. Sir Caramello is exactly like that. You can see that he still gets excited when he sees a crowd. I am very proud to say that we are currently the highest scoring Indian combination at the Grand Prix level. And of course we were the first from India to win a quota for the Olympics so in our own way we are breaking records," says Agarwalla.

While having a relaxed horse going into any tournament makes complete sense from a competitive perspective, Agarwalla says it goes beyond it. "I want him to get into a slightly relaxed state of mind before we restart training. For me that's the basic goal of horsemanship. When people get into the sport, it's almost never the case that the first thought is — 'I want to go to the Olympics or I want to win a medal'. The first reason almost anyone gets into the sport is because you love horses. I think it's very important that this feeling is maintained, no matter what your goals are. Of course, you know, everybody wants to go to the Olympics but it's very important for me that this bond and this love and respect for horses is not forgotten,"

he says.

The bond between the horse and rider was one of the primary reasons Agarwalla chose to specialise in the dressage discipline. "All equestrian events require you to have a connection with your horse but perhaps it's more so in dressage. You can feel that the horse is happy, full of energy and wants to help you. When things go right you are in perfect sync with the horse. And you just feel that you are dancing with the horse. It's hard to recreate this with any other discipline," he says.

Even before he started dressage, it was this bond that developed Agarwalla's interest during the time he first started riding as an eight-year-old in Kolkata's Tollygunge club. "I didn't come from an equestrian family like nearly



WHILE HAVING A RELAXED HORSE GOING INTO ANY TOURNAMENT MAKES COMPLETE SENSE, FROM A COMPETITIVE PERSPECTIVE, AGARWALLA SAYS IT GOES BEYOND IT



every one else at the Olympics. When I first started riding, it was something I really enjoyed since I loved being around animals. Riding was just an excuse to spend time with a horse," says Agarwalla. Three years after he first started, he was making weekend trips to New Delhi in order to train. In 2017, he moved to Germany to hone his skills under the tutelage of 2004 Olympic champion, Hubertus Schmidt.

A special partnership

He acquired Sir Caramello two years later, when he was looking to try out for the Tokyo Olympics. And while there were thousands of horses available for sale, Agarwalla says he knew very soon that the honey-coloured Sir Caramello was the right one for him.

